



Glossary: Glossary Title

Estimated Time: 15 minutes

Welcomel This alphabetized glossary contains many terms used in this course.

| Term                                       | Definition                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5 whys                                     | A problem-solving method that identifies root causes by repeatedly asking "why" until the underlying cause is revealed.                                                   |
| Activity                                   | A task or action in a process, typically shown as a rectangle or rounded rectangle.                                                                                       |
| Activity-based costing (ABC)               | A costing method that allocates overhead and indirect costs to products or services based on the activities that drive those costs.                                       |
| Actor                                      | A user or external system that interacts with a process or system within a use case.                                                                                      |
| AI-assisted analysis                       | Leveraging generative AI tools to support problem definition, cause identification, and solution development in process improvement.                                      |
| AI Prompt                                  | A clear, structured instruction given to an AI system to guide output quality and ensure relevance to the user's goal.                                                    |
| AI-assisted visualization                  | The use of AI tools such as Lucidchart AI, Gemini, and Claude to automatically create process maps, SIPOCs, or workflow diagrams from text inputs.                        |
| Automation tool                            | Software such as UiPath, Zapier, or Monday.com that executes automated workflows across business systems.                                                                 |
| Balanced scorecard                         | A strategic planning tool that links business activities to organizational goals through four perspectives: financial, customer, internal processes, and learning/growth. |
| Brainstorming                              | A creative group or individual technique used to generate a wide range of ideas or solutions during analysis or problem-solving sessions.                                 |
| Business analyst (BA)                      | A professional responsible for identifying business needs, analyzing processes, and recommending solutions that deliver value to stakeholders.                            |
| Business process                           | A collection of related tasks or activities that produce a specific outcome or service for customers or stakeholders.                                                     |
| Business Process Model and Notation (BPMN) | A standardized visual language used to model complex business processes with symbols representing events, activities, gateways, and flows.                                |
| Change implementation guide                | A structured outline for planning, communicating, and executing change initiatives while minimizing resistance.                                                           |
| Change readiness checklist                 | A tool to evaluate whether the organization, teams, and systems are prepared for change implementation.                                                                   |
| Connector                                  | A symbol used in process mapping to show continuity between parts of a process, either on the same page or across multiple pages.                                         |
| Continuous improvement (Kaizen)            | The ongoing pursuit of incremental process enhancements aimed at improving efficiency, quality, and customer satisfaction.                                                |
| Control chart                              | A graphical SPC tool that tracks process variation and identifies when performance is outside expected limits.                                                            |
| Control plan                               | A document outlining how improvements will be monitored, who is responsible, and what actions to take if performance declines.                                            |
| Cost driver                                | A measurable factor that directly causes or influences the cost of an activity, such as machine hours or the number of orders.                                            |
| Cross-functional process                   | A workflow that spans multiple departments or roles, requiring clear coordination and visibility.                                                                         |
| Current state map                          | The VSM showing how a process operates today, including all steps, wait times, and inefficiencies.                                                                        |
| Current state process                      | A model that represents how a process currently operates, including existing steps, roles, and pain points.                                                               |
| Customer                                   | The internal or external recipient of the outputs.                                                                                                                        |
| Cycle time (CT)                            | The total time required to complete one process activity from start to finish.                                                                                            |
| Data flow diagram (DFD)                    | A diagram that shows how data moves through a process or system, including inputs, outputs, and storage points.                                                           |
| Decision (diamond)                         | A symbol in a process map that represents a point where a choice must be made, often leading to different paths.                                                          |
| Decomposition                              | Breaking a large process or function into smaller, more manageable subprocesses or activities.                                                                            |
| DMAIC                                      | A Six Sigma problem-solving framework: Define, Measure, Analyze, Improve, Control.                                                                                        |
| Document symbol                            | A shape in process mapping that represents a physical or digital document used or produced in a process.                                                                  |
| Eight wastes (DOWNTIME)                    | The key types of waste in Lean: Defects, Overproduction, Waiting, Non-utilized talent, Transportation, Inventory, Motion, and Extra processing.                           |
| End event                                  | A BPMN symbol indicating where a process concludes.                                                                                                                       |
| Entity relationship diagram (ERD)          | A data modeling technique that visually represents the relationships between key data entities such as customers, products, or orders.                                    |
| Event-based gateway                        | A gateway where the next path is determined by an event rather than a decision.                                                                                           |
| Exception path                             | An alternate flow taken when a condition is not met such as "payment rejected."                                                                                           |
| Exclusive gateway (XOR)                    | A decision point where only one path is taken based on a condition.                                                                                                       |
| Fishbone (Ishikawa) diagram                | A visual root-cause tool categorizing potential causes under headings such as People, Process, Technology, and Management.                                                |
| Flow                                       | The smooth, continuous movement of materials, information, or work through a process without interruptions or delays.                                                     |
| Flowchart                                  | A standardized type of process map using symbols such as rectangles (activities), diamonds (decisions), and ovals (start/end).                                            |
| Functional process map                     | A process map showing detailed steps, activities, and relationships within a single function or department.                                                               |
| Functionality                              | How well the process performs its intended purpose.                                                                                                                       |
| FURPS model                                | A framework used to evaluate processes or systems based on Functionality, Usability, Reliability, Performance, and Supportability.                                        |
| Future state map                           | A redesigned VSM representing the desired process after improvements have been implemented.                                                                               |
| Future state modeling                      | Using data and process mapping to simulate the potential impact of improvements before implementation.                                                                    |
| Gateway                                    | A diamond-shaped decision point that splits or merges paths based on conditions or events.                                                                                |
| Generative AI (Gen AI)                     | Artificial intelligence capable of generating new text, visuals, or designs to support process documentation, mapping, and idea generation.                               |
| Handoff                                    | The transfer of work, information, or responsibility between roles, departments, or systems.                                                                              |
| Impact versus effort matrix                | A visual tool that categorizes improvement ideas by potential impact and implementation effort to prioritize actions.                                                     |
| Input                                      | The data, materials, or information needed for a process to execute.                                                                                                      |
| Intermediate event                         | An event that occurs during the process such as a message received, a timer, or an error.                                                                                 |
| Inventory                                  | Materials or work-in-progress waiting between process steps; often a sign of imbalance or inefficiency.                                                                   |
| Kano model                                 | A customer satisfaction model that classifies features as Basic, Performance, or Delighters to guide which improvements most impact satisfaction.                         |
| Lane                                       | A horizontal or vertical section in a swimlane diagram representing a participant (role, team, department, or system).                                                    |
| Lead time                                  | The total time it takes for a product or service to move through an entire process, including both value-added and waiting time.                                          |
| Lean methodology                           | A systematic approach that eliminates non-value-added activities ("waste") while maximizing value delivered to customers.                                                 |
| Lean thinking                              | A philosophy focused on maximizing customer value while minimizing waste by improving process flow and eliminating non-value-added activities.                            |

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| MoSCoW method                          | A prioritization framework that classifies initiatives as Must Have, Should Have, Could Have, or Won't Have based on urgency and value.                                   |
| Narrative step description             | The text explaining "what happens" in each activity, who performs it, and what inputs/outputs are involved.                                                               |
| Non-value-added activity               | Work that consumes time or resources but does not contribute to customer value.                                                                                           |
| Off-page connector                     | A process mapping symbol that indicates the continuation of a process on another page, labeled for reference.                                                             |
| Output                                 | The product, service, or information produced by the process.                                                                                                             |
| Parallel gateway                       | A point where multiple paths proceed simultaneously.                                                                                                                      |
| Performance                            | Speed, efficiency, and throughput of the process.                                                                                                                         |
| PESTLE analysis                        | A tool for examining external factors, Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Legal, and Environmental, that affect an organization's strategy.                      |
| Porter's five forces                   | A framework for analyzing the competitive forces within an industry: supplier power, buyer power, threat of new entrants, threat of substitutes, and competitive rivalry. |
| Predefined process (subprocess)        | A process mapping symbol representing a standardized or reusable process defined elsewhere in documentation.                                                              |
| Process (in SIPOC)                     | The high-level steps that transform inputs into outputs—usually 4–7 steps.                                                                                                |
| Process automation                     | Using technology or software tools to perform repetitive or rules-based tasks with minimal human intervention, improving speed and accuracy.                              |
| Process boundary                       | The defined start and end points of a process used to avoid scope creep.                                                                                                  |
| Process efficiency                     | The ratio of value-added time to total lead time, expressed as a percentage.                                                                                              |
| Process handbook                       | A catalog of an organization's core processes, interdependencies, and descriptions—serving as a "single source of truth."                                                 |
| Process improvement                    | A structured effort to identify inefficiencies, eliminate waste, and enhance performance in an existing workflow.                                                         |
| Process map                            | A visual representation of a process showing the sequence of steps, decision points, and flow of information or tasks.                                                    |
| Process mapping                        | The practice of visually documenting the steps, decisions, roles, and flows in a business process to understand and improve it.                                           |
| Process model                          | A visual representation of how work is performed in an organization, often showing inputs, outputs, roles, and decision points.                                           |
| Process narrative                      | A written description that explains each step of a process map, providing context, roles, tools, triggers, and notes.                                                     |
| Process optimization                   | Refining and adjusting an improved process to reach peak efficiency, quality, and cost-effectiveness through data analysis and redesign.                                  |
| Process reengineering                  | A radical redesign of a process from the ground up to achieve major improvements in cost, quality, service, or speed.                                                     |
| Process reliability                    | The probability that a process performs correctly without failure over a specific time period; often measured through uptime or consistency.                              |
| Process trigger                        | The event or condition that starts a process or subprocess.                                                                                                               |
| Reliability                            | Consistency and accuracy of process outcomes.                                                                                                                             |
| Requirements traceability matrix (RTM) | A tool linking business requirements to specific improvements, owners, measures, and validation criteria to maintain alignment.                                           |
| Risk matrix                            | A grid used to evaluate risks by plotting likelihood versus impact, helping prioritize which risks require attention.                                                     |
| Root cause                             | The underlying issue that drives process problems, surfaced through mapping, narratives, or FURPS analysis.                                                               |
| Root cause analysis (RCA)              | A structured process for identifying the true cause(s) of a problem to prevent recurrence.                                                                                |
| Scenario                               | A narrative or example describing how a process or system operates under specific conditions; often used to identify challenges and define a desired "To-Be" state.       |
| Sequence flow                          | Arrows in a process map or BPMN diagram that show the order of activities.                                                                                                |
| SIPOC diagram                          | A high-level mapping tool summarizing Suppliers, Inputs, Process, Outputs, and Customers of an end-to-end process.                                                        |
| Six sigma                              | A data-driven methodology that reduces process variation and defects to improve consistency and quality.                                                                  |
| SMART goal                             | A goal-setting framework ensuring that objectives are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.                                                         |
| Stakeholder                            | Any individual or group affected by, or with an interest in, a process, project, or system.                                                                               |
| Standard work                          | Documented, repeatable best practices that define the most efficient way to complete a process consistently.                                                              |
| Start event                            | A BPMN symbol indicating where a process begins.                                                                                                                          |
| Statistical process control (SPC)      | The use of control charts and data to monitor process performance and stability over time.                                                                                |
| Strategy analysis                      | A business analysis area focused on defining strategic goals, assessing current capabilities, and recommending initiatives to achieve desired outcomes.                   |
| Sub-optimization                       | When one part of a system improves at the expense of the overall performance of the system.                                                                               |
| Subprocess                             | A group of related activities collapsed into a single element to simplify complex process diagrams.                                                                       |
| Supplier                               | The individual, system, or organization providing inputs to a process.                                                                                                    |
| Supportability                         | Ability to monitor, sustain, and improve the process over time (dashboards, documentation, and metrics).                                                                  |
| Sustaining the gain                    | The practice of maintaining improvements over time by embedding controls, monitoring, and reinforcement into daily operations.                                            |
| Swimlane diagram                       | A type of process map that divides steps into lanes representing roles, departments, or systems to show responsibility and handoffs.                                      |
| System reliability (multiplicative)    | The combined reliability of sequential processes, calculated by multiplying individual process uptimes.                                                                   |
| Systems thinking                       | A holistic approach that views processes as interdependent parts of a larger system, focusing on how changes in one area affect the whole.                                |
| Throughput                             | The total output or units completed within a specific period of time.                                                                                                     |
| To-be process                          | A model representing how a process is intended to function after improvements or changes have been implemented.                                                           |
| Uptime                                 | The percentage of time a process, system, or machine is available for use and functioning correctly.                                                                      |
| Usability                              | How easy the process is to execute, including systems, interfaces, and steps required.                                                                                    |
| Use case                               | A description of how a user (actor) interacts with a system to achieve a specific goal; outlines actions, system responses, and outcomes.                                 |
| Validation                             | The process of reviewing a process model or diagram with stakeholders to ensure accuracy, completeness, and real-world alignment.                                         |
| Value stream map (VSM)                 | A visual tool used to analyze and document the flow of materials and information from process start to finish, identifying value-added and non-value-added time.          |
| Value-added activity                   | Work that directly contributes to meeting customer requirements or improving the product or service.                                                                      |
| Version control                        | The practice of tracking revisions to process documentation and designating an owner responsible for updates.                                                             |